POSC 3710: European Politics

10/19/2026: ELECTORAL SYSTEMS

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Britain May Change the Rules

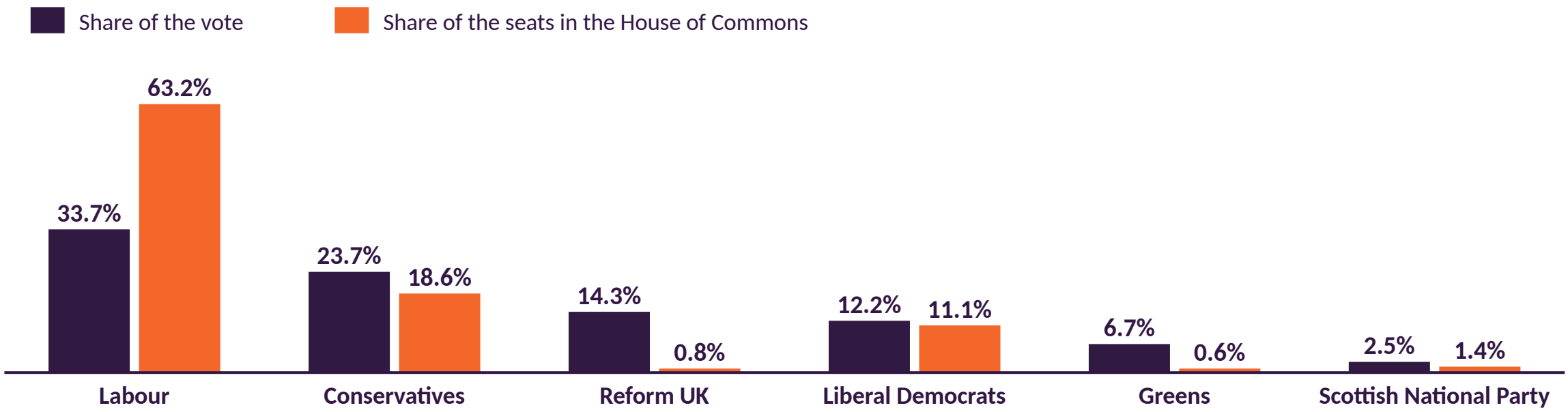
- September 29, 2026: Andy Burnham, Britain’s Labour prime minister, announces a commission on electoral reform
- Labour will run on “a manifesto commitment to change the electoral system”
- His warning: today’s rules could put a party in power “with 30% of the vote or less”
- We’ve seen this story before…
- What do you all think: would Labour gain seats under new rules, or lose them?



The 2024 election: Keir Starmer (left), who led Labour to victory, debates Rishi Sunak, the Conservative prime minister

In 2024 Labour won 33.7% of the vote in Britain. What share of the seats did it win?

A	B	C	D
34%	45%	55%	63%



650 seats; Labour won 411. Reform UK won more votes than the Liberal Democrats, and 5 seats to their 72. It was the least proportional election in British history.

NOTE – it's not Gerrymandering (per se). A natural consequence of first past the post.

From today's reading: Gallagher and Mitchell

A Minimum Definition of Democracy

- Every adult citizen has the right to vote periodically
  - To choose who governs, and to hold politicians accountable
- The type of election is not specified
  - Plurality, runoffs, ranked choice, proportional, mixed
- Nor is the timing
  - Fixed terms (USA, Norway), a maximum term (most of Europe), a hybrid (Sweden)
- An electoral system: the rules for "how votes are cast" and how they are "converted into seats"

From today's reading: Gallagher and Mitchell

European electoral systems: three ideal types

SINGLE-MEMBER DISTRICTS

One winner per district

- Plurality: the most votes wins. Britain, the United States
- Majority: a runoff if no one wins outright. France
- Ranked ballots: Australia

PROPORTIONAL REPRESENTATION

Seats in proportion to votes

- Party lists in districts with many seats: Spain, the Netherlands, Sweden
- Ireland: voters rank the candidates, in districts of three to five seats
    - My op-ed (and other research) proposes a similar plan for the US

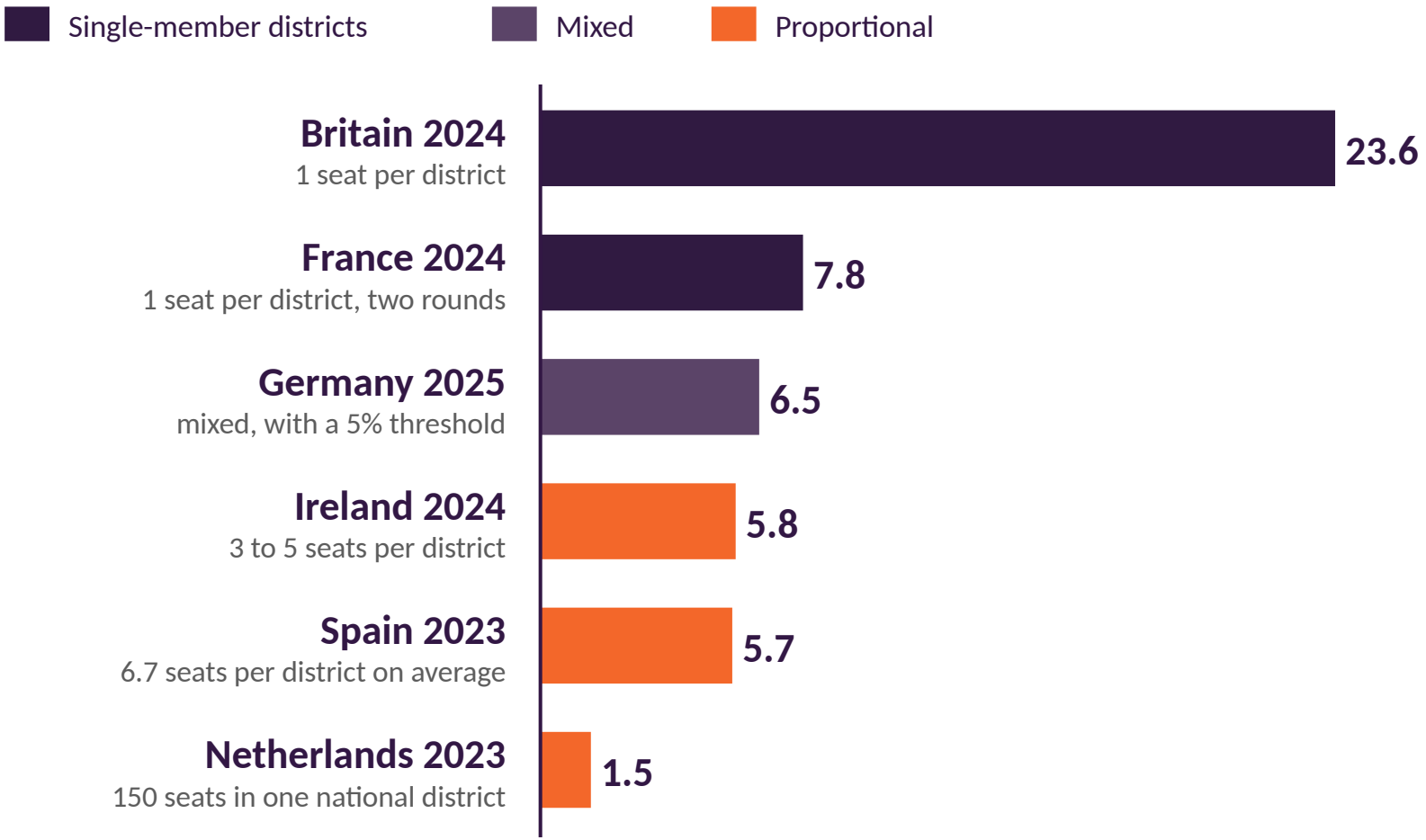
MIXED SYSTEMS

Two votes: a candidate and a party

- Germany: list seats make the whole parliament proportional
- Hungary: most seats go to district winners. April 2026: 53% of the vote, 71% of the seats

Most European countries use (some form of) proportional representation. Britain and France are exceptions.

How far are seats from votes?



DISTRICT MAGNITUDE

The number of seats a district elects

"The smaller the average district magnitude, the greater the disproportionality."

The reading calls it one of the most robust findings in the field.

Measurement: The least squares index for the latest election: 0 means every party's share of seats equals its share of votes. Germany's threshold left 13.9% of voters without a party in the Bundestag in 2025.

Duverger's law

> ***"The simple-majority single-ballot system favours the two-party system."***
>
> Maurice Duverger, French political scientist, 1951

THE MECHANICAL EFFECT

At the count

- The rules turn votes into seats
- A party that finishes second or third in every district wins nothing (Reform UK in 2024)

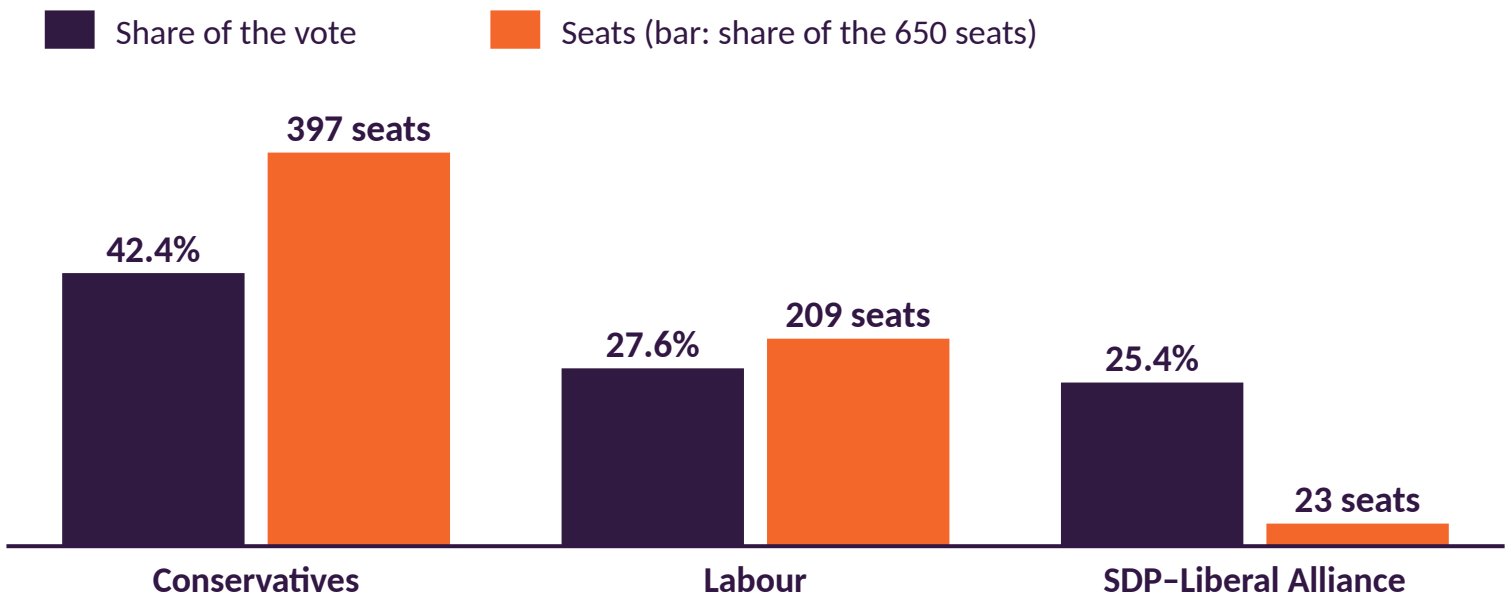
THE PSYCHOLOGICAL EFFECT

Before the vote

- Voters avoid "wasting their votes on sure losers"
- Candidates and donors stay away from parties that cannot win

Britain, 1983: Labour won 27.6% of the vote and 209 seats. The SDP–Liberal Alliance won 25.4%. How many seats?

A	B	C	D
23	**62**	**120**	**190**



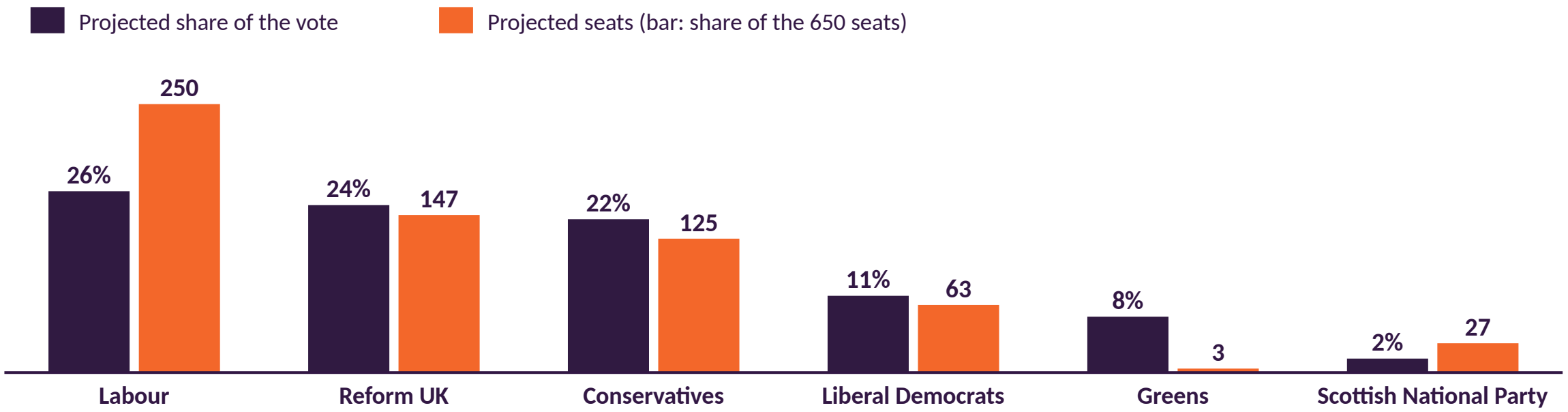


Margaret Thatcher, prime minister of Britain, 1979–90

The Alliance was two parties running together: the Liberals and the new Social Democratic Party. Thatcher's Conservatives won 61% of the seats with 42.4% of the vote.

A September 2026 projection for Britain: the Greens win 8% of the vote and 3 seats. The Scottish National Party wins 2%. How many seats?

A	B	C	D
1	9	27	61



Key point: The SNP runs only in Scotland's 57 districts.

Disproportionality in winner-take-all elections

	VOTES	SEATS	WHY?
France 2002: the center-right UMP	**33%**	**62%**	The largest party wins most of the runoffs
Britain 2005: Labour v Conservatives	**35.2%, 32.4%**	**355, 198**	Efficient votes: narrow wins in many districts
Britain 2010: Liberal Democrats	**23%**	**9%**	Small parties are punished
Britain 2024: Reform UK	**14.3%**	**5 of 650**	So are votes spread evenly across the country
Britain 2024: Plaid Cymru, in Wales	**0.7%**	**4 of 650**	Regionally concentrated parties are rewarded



Nigel Farage, leader of Reform UK and a member of Britain's Parliament since 2024

France's Socialists in 2012: 29% of the vote, nearly half the seats.

HANDS UP

From today's reading: Gallagher and Mitchell

Which matters more to you?

A LOCAL MEMBER AND A CLEAR WINNER

Single-member districts

- One representative for your district
- One party usually governs alone, so voters know whom to hold accountable
- The price: Parties can win Majorities with even 1/3 of the votes

SEATS THAT MATCH VOTES

Proportional representation

- Each party's share of seats is close to its share of votes
- More parties in parliament, and a wider range of views
- The price: "a coalition government is nearly inevitable," and it forms after the vote

"With only one level of seat allocation, we are forced to sacrifice a bit of one desirable property in order to get more of the other."

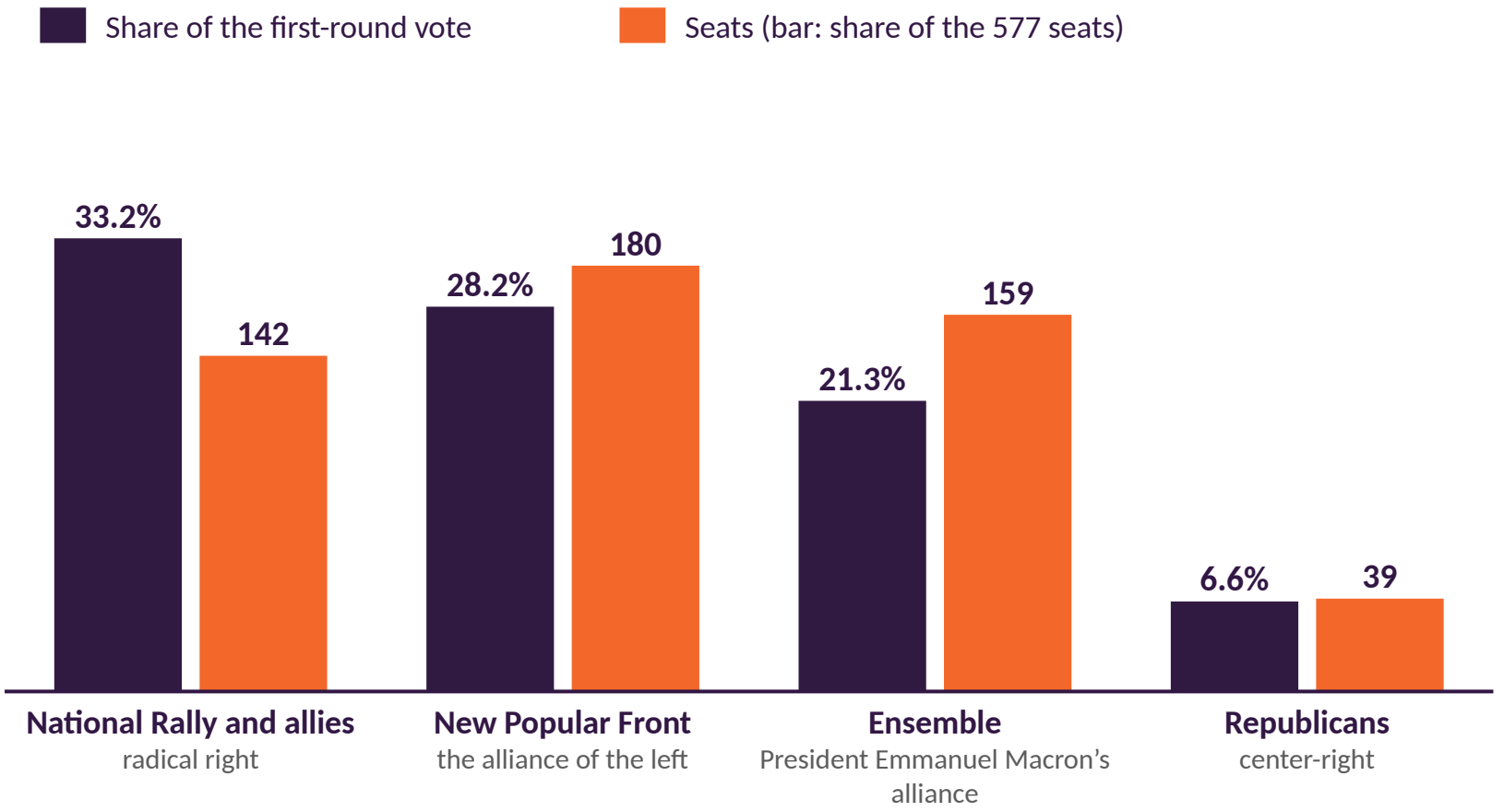
France: Majority Elections with Runoffs

- Single-member districts, as in Britain and the United States
- First round: a candidate with a majority wins the seat
- No majority: the top two, and anyone over 12.5% of registered voters, advance
- Second round: the most votes wins
- Third-placed candidates often stand aside
- “Vote with your heart in the first round, vote with your head in the second”



Marine Le Pen of the National Rally, a candidate for president of France in 2027

France 2024: votes in the first round, seats after the second



BETWEEN THE ROUNDS

- Three or more candidates qualified in 311 districts
- 216 candidates of the left and center withdrew, to unite against the National Rally
- Only 91 districts still had more than two candidates

577 seats, 289 for a majority: no bloc has one. The party that came first in votes came third in seats.

Proportional Representation

- Most European countries use proportional representation (PR)
- The share of seats roughly equals the share of votes
  - How closely depends on the size of the districts and on thresholds
- Several parties in parliament, and a wider range of views
- Easier for new parties to form and win seats
- Frequent coalition governments

From today's reading: Gallagher and Mitchell

Open List or Closed List



VAL TILL KOMMUNFULLMÄKTIGE

Arbetarepartiet-Socialdemokraterna

Du får bara markera en av dessa **anmälda** kandidater.

1. Ulric Andersen, 60, oppositionsråd, Skå
2. Gun Häll, 57, studiestödshandläggare, Stenhamra
3. Sveneric Larsson, 67, f.d. närpolischef, Adelsö
4. Eleonor Eriksson, 32, studerande, Stenhamra
5. Georg Gustafsson, 44, egen företagare, Ekebyhov
6. Elisabeth Palm, 54, tandsköterska, Stenhamra
7. Fredrik Sirberg, 33, byggnadsarbetare, Munsö
8. Marianne Jacobsson, 75, f.d. rektor, Skå
9. Johan Hammarström, 19, personlig assistent, Väsby
10. Inger Andersen, 59, enhetschef, Skå
11. Lars Holmström, 39, byggnadsarbetare, Stenhamra
12. Hanna Svensson, 27, ombudsman, Helgö
13. Lars Isaksson, 64, f.d. verkst. direktör, Träkvista
14. Madeleine Mjöberg-Quanne, 35, administratör, Närlunda

A Social Democratic ballot for a Swedish municipal council: "You may mark only one of these candidates"

- Closed lists (Spain, Portugal): the party sets the order
  - Wins 15 seats: the first 15 names are elected
- Open lists (Finland, Poland): voters' preference votes decide who is elected
- Flexible lists (Sweden, the Netherlands): the party ranks, but a candidate with enough personal votes moves up
- Hands up: who should rank a party's candidates, the party or its voters?

ACTIVITY

From today's reading: Gallagher and Mitchell

Threshold or not?

The case for a threshold: "preventing excessive fragmentation and thereby making it easier to form stable governments."

THE NETHERLANDS: NO THRESHOLD

0.67% of the vote wins a seat

- 15 parties won seats in 2025
- The largest has 26 of 150 seats
- Forming a government took 117 days

GERMANY: 5%

Or win three districts

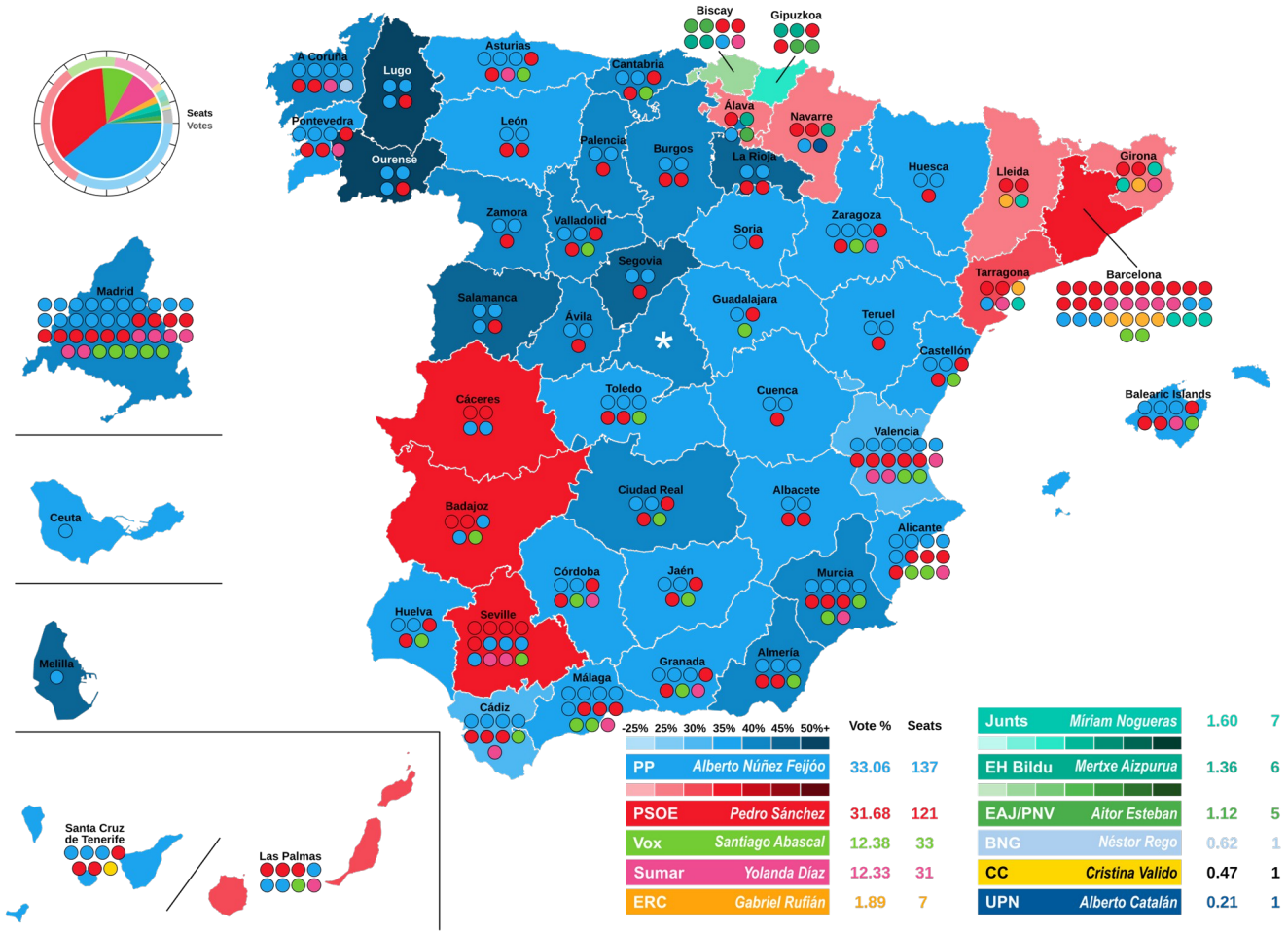
- 2025: the BSW won 4.98% and no seats. It was 9,529 votes short
- 13.9% of voters chose a party that won no seats
- With the BSW in, today's two-party government would have no majority

TURKEY, 2002: 10%

Two parties cleared

- 46% of votes went to parties that won no seats
- The winner, the AKP, took 66% of the seats with 34% of the vote
- The threshold has been 7% since 2022

Spain's hidden threshold



Spain implicitly has a threshold by splitting into 52 electoral constituencies

350 seats in 52 districts

6.7 seats per district on average

THE EFFECTIVE THRESHOLD

About 75 ÷ (seats + 1)

2 seats: 25% of the vote

5 seats: 12.5%

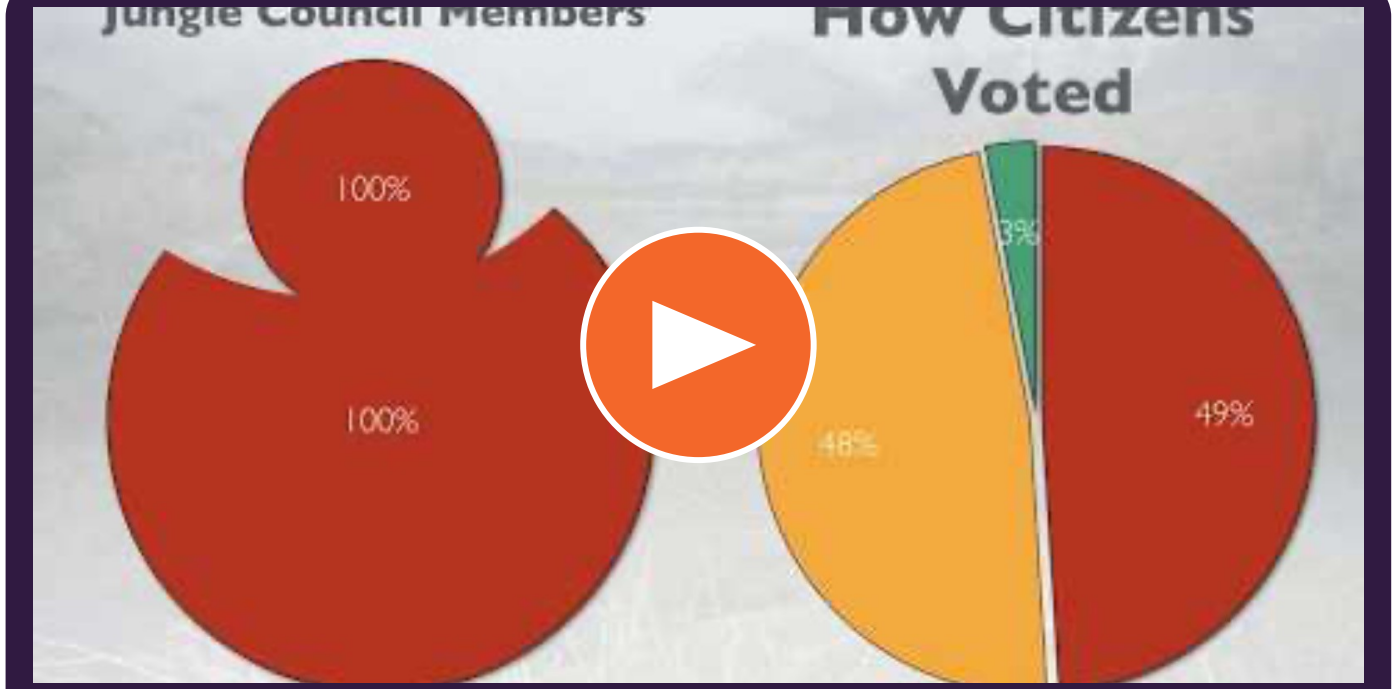
10 seats: 6.8%

37 seats (Madrid): 2%

2023

The People's Party: 33.1% of the vote, 39.1% of the seats. Vox: 12.4% of the vote, 9.4% of the seats.

Mixed-member proportional representation: two votes



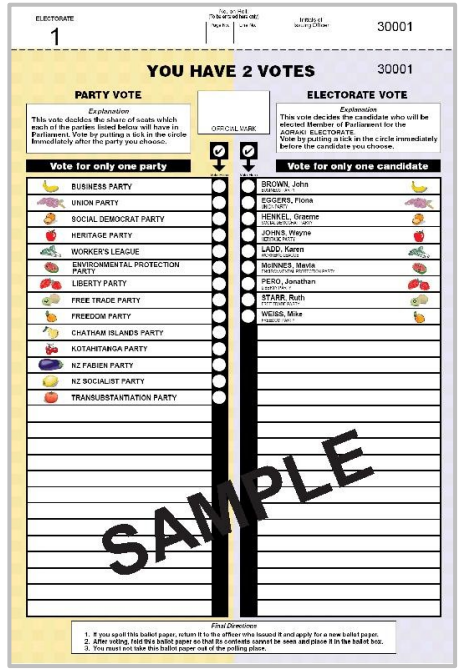
Mixed-Member Proportional Representation Explained

CGP Grey · ▶ Plays in full

Click the card to play · fallback: youtube.com/watch?v=QT0I-sdoSXU



Germany, 2005: the first vote is for a district candidate, the second for a party



New Zealand: a party vote and an electorate vote

Both ballots begin with the same words: “You have 2 votes.”

From today's reading: Gallagher and Mitchell

Mixed-Member Systems: The Best of Both Worlds?



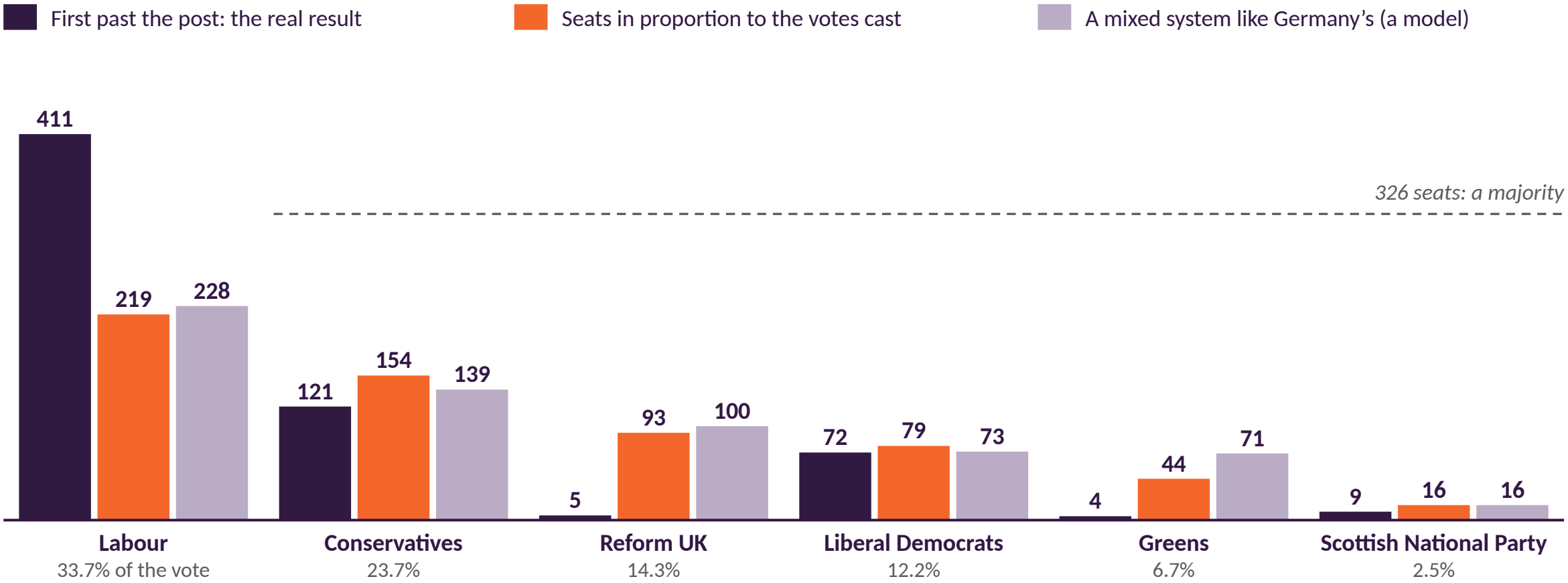
Friedrich Merz (CDU), chancellor of Germany. Fifteen CDU district winners got no seat in 2025

- You get a local member from your first vote
- List seats bring each party up to its share of the party vote
- Gallagher and Mitchell: a way to "have our cake and eat it"
- Germany since 2023: 630 seats, shared out by the party vote alone
  - In 2025, 23 district winners got no seat
- How important is local representation?

ACTIVITY

Same votes, three parliaments: Britain, 2024

In pairs, before the click: 650 seats. Labour won 33.7% of the vote and Reform UK 14.3%. How many seats each, if seats matched votes?



The mixed-system column is the Electoral Reform Society's model, built from a survey of how people would vote under those rules. 28% said they had voted tactically in 2024.

America’s Two-Party Problem

- “In any other country, Joe Biden and I would not be in the same party.”
  - Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, Democratic representative from New York, in 2020, when Biden was running for president
- In 2024, fewer than 10% of U.S. House races were competitive
- A proposal: bigger districts that elect several members each, in proportion to the vote



The New York Times, January 14, 2025

Georgia: 14 seats, two ways to fill them

TODAY: 14 SINGLE-MEMBER DISTRICTS

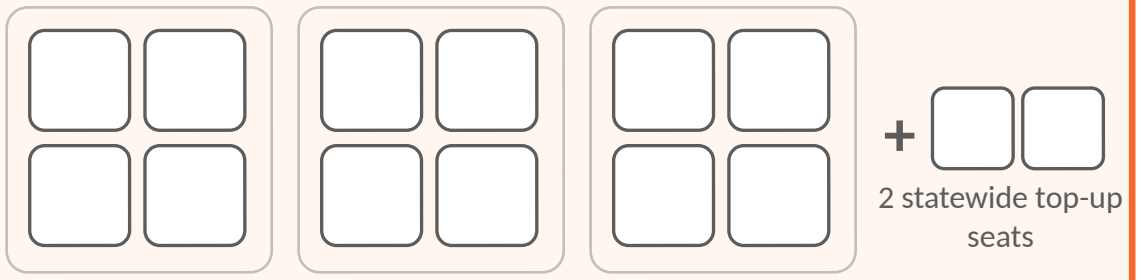
R R R R R R R

R R D D D D D

9 Republicans, 5 Democrats

in a state that votes about 50–50. Competitive seats: zero.

THE PROPOSAL: PROPORTIONAL DISTRICTS



7 Republicans, 7 Democrats

on every simulated map: the same as the state's vote.

HARDER TO GERRYMANDER

Moving voters from one district to another no longer moves seats

MINORITY VOTERS

A group with 20% of a district's voters, voting together, can elect a candidate

THE OBSTACLE

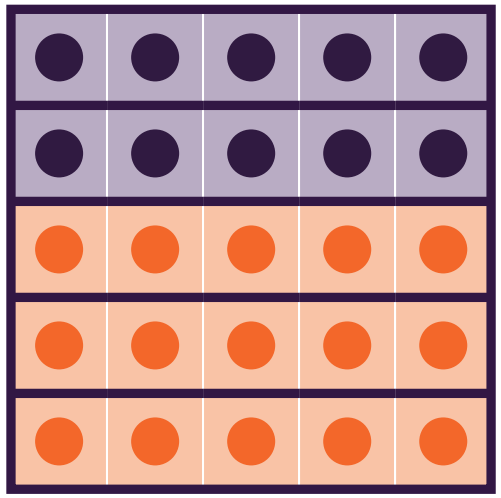
A 1967 federal law requires single-member districts for the U.S. House

ACTIVITY

From today's reading: Horne and Oldham

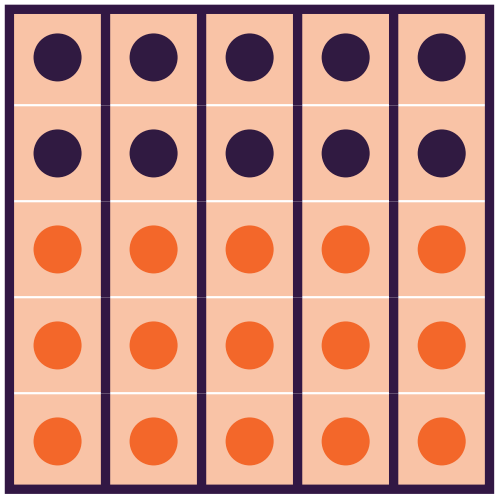
Draw the districts: 25 voters, 5 districts of 5

Purple has 10 voters and Orange has 15. In pairs: draw five districts of five neighboring voters each, so that Purple wins the most districts.



By row

Orange 3 · Purple 2



By column

Orange 5 · Purple 0

Can we draw one for purple?

Orange 2 · Purple 3

ONE DISTRICT, FIVE SEATS

Proportional rules

Orange 3 · Purple 2

There are no lines to draw.

"Proportional districts cannot be manipulated like single-winner districts, where parties can win more seats simply by shifting voters between districts."

Key Points

- Electoral systems turn votes into seats, and politicians choose them
- The fewer seats per district, the further seats stray from votes
- Duverger’s law: a mechanical effect and a psychological effect
- Every system trades proportionality against local representation and fewer, larger, parties
- Under debate this year: Britain, Italy